JOEL STEVICK

Business Development Representative | 25+ Years Building Product
Frostburg, MD | joelstevick@gmail.com | LinkedIn

After 25+ years of building product, I have discovered that I get more reward from finding the next customer than from shipping the next feature. I found this out building HowardsLantern.com, which I created to generate income while waiting to land my next engineering job. Once the first release shipped, it was time to build the list and start making calls. After my first day on the phone, I woke up the next morning knowing this is how I want to spend the foreseeable part of my career: I could not wait to get up and start mining for deals. The part of selling I want to own is the front of it: finding the right accounts, getting the first conversation, hearing what the buyer actually needs, and handing the rep a meeting worth taking. At Zonar I spent five years building EVIR Web for the fleet and transportation directors I would be calling, so I know what they ask for before I dial.

ZONAR PRODUCT KNOWLEDGE

I was the team lead for EVIR Web and Inspection Builder, and I have strong overall product knowledge of the Zonar application family.

OUTBOUND RECORD

Howard's Lantern, Aug 2026 to present, every number from the lead sheet: 3,122 driving schools sourced from ten state licensing registers; 39 dials, about 20 live conversations, and 9 proposal requests on the first full calling day; 19 callbacks booked and 4 schools marked interested in the pipeline today; 27 cold intro emails sent; every dial, no, voicemail, and callback date logged.

EXPERIENCE

Founder - Built the Product, Doing the Outbound Myself
Howard's Lantern (howardslantern.com) | Self-employed, Frostburg, MD | Aug 2026 - Present

- Built Howard's Lantern, a learner's-permit study app for all 50 states, and sell it to driving schools as a co-branded partner program with referral codes, per-learner progress, a commission ledger, and monthly payouts. I built the product and I am the sales team.
- Built the lead list: 3,122 driving schools pulled from ten state licensing registers (CA, NY, TX, NJ, WA, FL, MD, IL, OR, VA), the first nine states in about three days, deduplicated and worked from a shared sheet with claims, cooldowns, and callback dates so no lead is double-dialed or dropped.
- First full calling day: 39 dials, about 20 live conversations, 9 schools asked for a proposal, 8 said no and one hung up, 17 voicemails each left with a callback date, and 20 intro emails sent the same evening.
- Rewrote the pitch from what owners said on the phone: the first opener led with the commission and nobody cared, so I rebuilt the call around the problem schools actually have, the student who calls before they have a permit.
- Built an AI-assisted calling workflow: it hands me the next lead with the pitch and voicemail fitted to that state, logs each outcome, and suggests opener changes from the feedback. The pitch, voicemail, and intro email have all been rewritten this way, with Spanish versions where the state has them, backed by a sourced objection sheet against the three competitors schools name.
- Qualify before I dial: each school's own website is checked for whether it already sells written-test prep, so the queue cold-calls the schools with the gap first.
- Cold email with a daily send cap and an opt-out footer from day two; Spanish-named schools in Spanish-pack states get the intro email in Spanish first.
- Fed the calls back into the product: per-student invites and the email telling a school the day a student is ready to sit the test both shipped because of what schools said on the phone.
- Run the marketing too: Google Ads, SEO, and AI-generated short videos published to YouTube and TikTok.

Consultant - AI Products, Founder-Level Engineering
Pilot & Pixel | Concurrent Contract, Remote | Jan 2024 - Present

- Built and shipped three AI products as a one-person team: a multi-tenant RAG platform with an embeddable chat widget, a desktop document-intelligence client, and an offline PII-redaction app.
- Launched a paid Legal Edition of the redaction app, sold through direct download, the Mac App Store, and the Microsoft Store.

- Launched PalabraEdu, a five-language real-time education SaaS with Stripe subscriptions, in roughly six weekends.
- Ran the customer feedback loop: in-app feedback flows into GitHub Issues with two-way replies, so every report gets a human answer and a tracked resolution.

Team Lead - EVIR Web and Inspection Builder

Zonar Systems | Full-time, Seattle, WA (remote) | Jan 2021 - Aug 2026

- Led the web application for EVIR, Zonar's verified electronic vehicle inspection, used by school bus, transit, and commercial fleets to prove pre- and post-trip inspections were done and to route defects to maintenance.
- Owned the EVIR web app end to end for nearly five years: features, releases, and the fixes the field asked for. The requests of fleet and transportation directors were my backlog.
- Replaced the legacy Angular EVIR Web and Inspection Builder applications with React in 60 days and migrated existing users without service disruption.

Senior Developer / Team Lead

US Mobilesoft | Rockville, MD | 2004 - 2024

- Built OpenAI-integrated summarization and AI-assisted editing tools; led a local-first Ionic/Angular social app for iOS backed by Node.js microservices.

Senior Software Engineer

Ic-1 (acquired by The Swift Group) | Concurrent Contract | 2020 - 2021

-

Software Architect

Alexus | Gaithersburg, MD | 1997 - 2004

- Led a team of seven engineers building a natural-language search engine for one of the first online recruitment tools.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer | Cisco Systems / Digital | 1992 - 1996. Built Windows NFS/print clients, TCP/IP kernel code, and Ethernet device drivers

PUBLICATIONS

The 25x Developer | Co-author, Palabra Press, 2026. Practical methods for AI-assisted development, written for working engineers and the people who manage them.

EDUCATION

Applied Mathematics | George Washington University, Washington, DC | Four years on the Dean's List; graduate statistics grader; department-sanctioned tutor